

Course report SF2222 Citizens, Politicians and the Media

Spring semester 2025

The course is a joint venture between the Department of Political Science and the Department of Journalism, Media and Communication. It is an elective course in the Master's Programme in Political Science and a compulsory course in the Master's Programme in Political Communication. It is given in the first module of the second semester, and awards 15 credits/hp upon completion.

The aim of the course is to give students the conceptual and theoretical tools to analyze how “the will of the people” – as a major goal of democracies – can be or is achieved. The course draws on and teaches the latest research on voting behaviour, political psychology, political participation, political representation, political communication, journalism, and media.

The course is thematically structured around four segments: the first is about more normative considerations and theories of democracy, political and media systems; the second investigates the role of citizens, drawing on individual-level research on public opinion, political participation, and voting behaviour; the third covers politicians as representatives, including prominent theories of representation; and the fourth covers research on media and communication with relevance for democracy .

The course is organizationally structured into two different parts: the first consists of input from lecturers through 14 different lectures, concluded with a written exam; and the second consists of a mix of peer-to-peer learning and individual meetings with lecturers to write a literature review that is presented and discussed at the very end of the course.

The course has been running for several years already, albeit with changing lecturers. Unlike other courses in the master's programme, the course is fairly lecture intensive, and includes lectures given by researchers from different fields. Passing the course requires passing the written exam, the literature review, as well as peer-to-peer workshops, supervision meetings and an Academic Honesty test.

Completion rate

Out of the 38 students that were registered on the course 28 (74 percent) have fully completed the course (as of September 2025). Of these, in turn, 16 (57 percent) students received the grade G and 12 (43 percent) the grade VG. These statistics are very much comparable to previous years.

Assessment survey

Below are the results from the evaluation survey filled in by students (n= 24, corresponding to 63 percent of the students registered on the course). The response rate is much better compared to previous years and generally satisfactory. Setting aside time for completing the survey during the final seminar seems to have paid off.

Assessments, average between 1 (very bad) to 5 (very good)	<i>Score 2023</i>	<i>Score 2024</i>	<i>Score 2025</i>
Overall assessment of the course	4.5	4.0	4.3
... of lectures	4.2	4.5	4.4
... of teachers	4.7	4.4	4.6
... of the literature	4.1	3.8	4.0
... of the written exam	3.8	2.7	4.1
... of the first writing workshop (peer-to-peer)	4.0	4.3	4.0
... of the second writing workshop (peer-to-peer)	4.0	3.7	4.1
... of the personal supervision?	4.1	4.2	4.7
... of the final seminar	4.3	4.5	4.7
... of the course's organization	4.4	4.4	4.0
... of the workload (5=not at all demanding; 1= much too demanding)	2.5	2.9	2.7

The results are overall similar to previous years (2023 and 2024) with one difference: the written exam was much more positively rated this year compared to 2024 but more similar (still better) than in 2023.

Positives

Several of the comments specifically praise the lecturers and the organization and structure of the course also gets very good reviews. It is also good to see that the written exam is more positively evaluated than in previous years, not least because a closed-book exam might become more relevant in the future with latest developments in AI. While it is difficult to say why the exam was more positively rated, this year we paid attention to framing it in positive ways. We stressed the overarching purpose of it and that we are not after detailed information. Still the low response rate last year could also account for the difference in evaluations.

Negatives

Some students stated in the open comments that the lectures and the associated reading was a bit repetitive. Additionally, some indicate a preference for better communication of what is expected (first 5 pages of review, student-led seminars, acting as discussant, final seminar). Some would like to have more time to choose a topic for the research review, did not think the supervision or workshops were necessary / helped them that much. Students would also like to have more intensive discussions, like during the final seminar.

Course coordinator's general evaluation and suggestions for the future

All in all, the course ran smoothly. The course content is deemed both interesting and intellectually stimulating by the students. Generally, the course structure is adequate, and the workload of the course seem to be reasonable.

Changes may be considered for 2026:

- Re-consider the teaching format of the course by introducing more (or only?) discussion-based seminars instead of lectures. This would possibly avoid repetition and address the wish to have more discussions. It would also align with the higher standard required of Master students compared to Bachelor students.
- Give students more time to choose a topic for the research review. This could increase the quality of the review and students' motivation.
- Make workshops and supervision voluntary instead of compulsory. This would address students concern of unnecessary or non-useful elements in the course and it would increase students' independence, aligning with the requirements of a Master's course.

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